

Portable Audio Devices

Flash Memory Audio Players Creative Rhomba NX

Specs: 128 MB, 2 AAA batteries, FM Tuner, Voice/FM Recording, 62 gm.



Our verdict: The Creative Rhomba NX provides excellent audio clarity. This, combined with features including voice recording, FM recording and line-in encoding, makes it a great buy. The inbuilt FM sensitivity option lets users adjust the signal strength of the FM tuner, a feature that we did not find in any other player in this category. Bundled with quality earphones, the Rhomba NX is a treat for audiophiles on the move.

Runner-up: **Creative MuVo Slim**

Micro Hard Drive-Based Portable Audio Players

Apple iPod Mini

Specs: 4 GB, Internal Lithium Battery, USB 2.0/FireWire, Contacts, Alarm, 102 gms.

Our verdict: The large display on the iPod Mini is a breeze to use; it displays six lines at a time, making browsing through hundreds of tracks easier. With 22 inbuilt preset equaliser modes, it more than makes up for not having a customisable equaliser. Fea-

tures like alarm, calendar and contacts take functionality to a different level. Pocketable and solidly built, the interface and button controls are designed for one-handed operation. With decent battery life, good audio quality and support for various formats, the iPod Mini is an outright winner.

Runner-up: **NA**

Apple iPod 20GB

Specs: 20 GB, Internal Lithium battery, USB 2.0 / FireWire, Contacts, Alarm, 158 gms

Our verdict: Scoring the highest on various parameters, the iPod 20GB easily beat contenders in this category. Unbeatable in ease of use and build quality, this fourth generation iPod scores over competition with the same features as the iPod Mini and is a great player for those who like to carry their entire collection. Though battery life was not the best, ergonomics, intuitive user interface and performance make it the winner.

Runner-up: **NA**



Printers

SoHo Printers

Canon Pixma iP4000

Specs: Five Colour Ink tanks, 4800x1200 dpi, PictBridge-compliant, Duplex printing and CD-R printing

Our Verdict: The latest crop of printers from Canon will live up to your expectations, with the right balance of performance and features. The Pixma iP4000 from Canon is the fastest inkjet printer we have tested so far. It took less than nine seconds

to print out our test page where other printers take 14 seconds to do the same job. Printouts from the Canon iP4000 are good and on par with competing models. Photograph printouts can be described as good, if not excellent. The new, though, design is aesthetically more pleasing and compact.

Runner-up: **HP Business Inkjet 1100dtn**



Flashback To December 2000

Creative Nomad II and Creative Nomad jukebox

Evolution: Portable audio players have come of age. They have evolved from the bulky Creative Nomad Jukebox to the sleek Apple iPod. Performance in terms of voice clarity, battery life and storage flexibility is better than what it used to be in 2000. A direct comparison tells us that the Creative Nomad Jukebox offered 6 GB storage only for music tracks while Apple's iPod offers 60 GB with the ability to store Photos, documents and music. Average battery life then was no more than 6 hours whereas today, you can easily get 15 hours of continuous play.

Epson Stylus Colour 880

Specs: USB/Parallel interface, 2400x1200 dpi, 100 pages, input paper tray

Evolution: Printing quality has improved to such a point that inkjet printers are now used for printing photographs. Features such as duplex printing, PictBridge compliance have also been added to the feature list. Printing speeds have improved drastically. The Epson Stylus Colour 880 was priced at Rs 21,800, three times the amount you will spend today for a decidedly better product.

